Vibe Coding Kills Open Source

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"I ship code I don't read."

Peter Steinberger, OpenClaw (2026)

"70-80-90% of code at Anthropic is written by Claude."

Dario Amodei, Axios AI+ Summit (2025)

What is “vibe coding”?

- User describes intent, gets working software
- AI agent selects and assembles open source packages
- **User never reads docs, files bugs, or engages with maintainers**

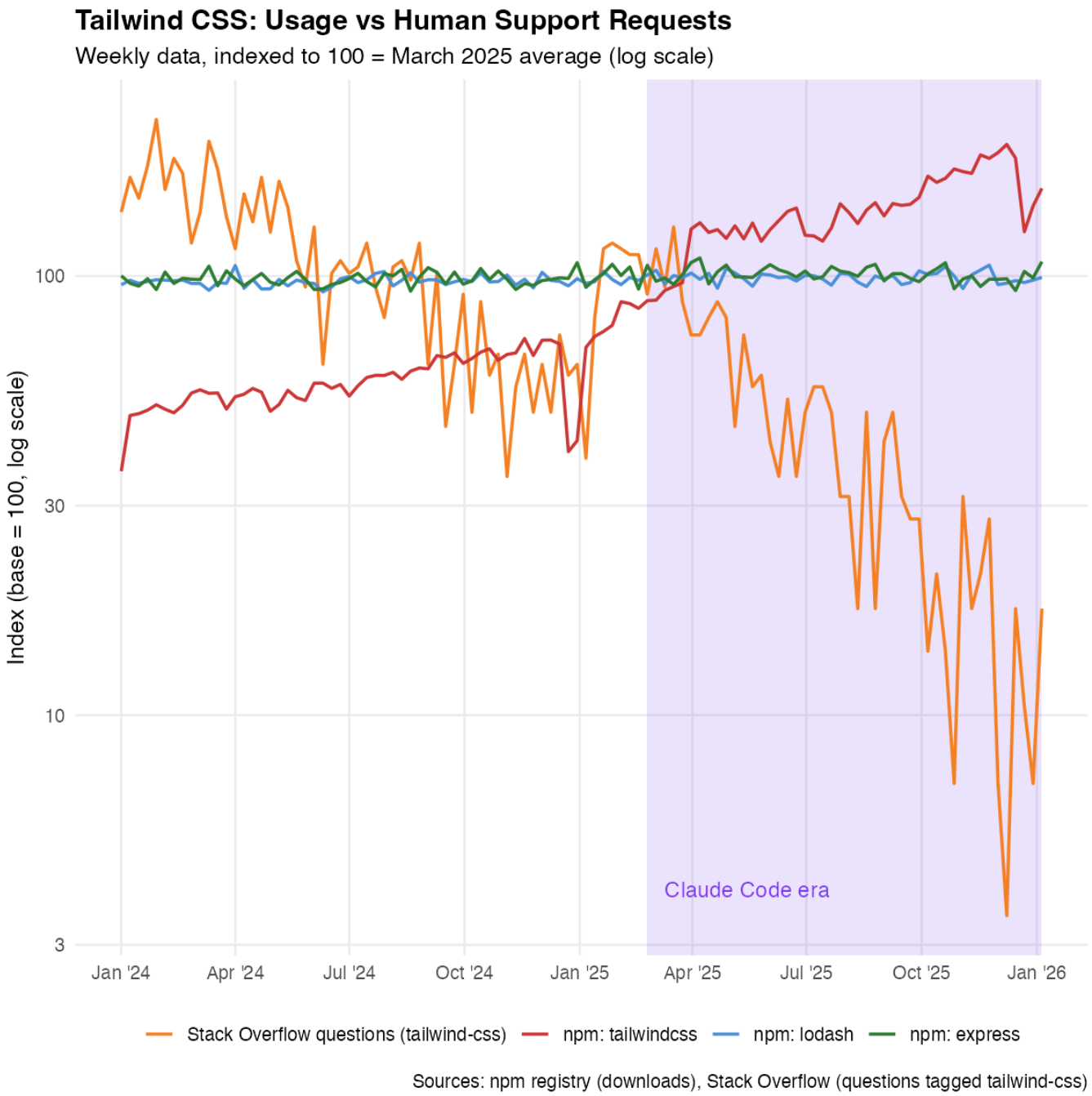
The puzzle

OSS usage $\uparrow$

OSS engagement $\downarrow$

How can both be true?

Tailwind CSS: A case study



"Traffic to our docs is down 40% despite Tailwind being more popular than ever. Revenue is down close to 80%."

Adam Wathan, Tailwind CSS creator (2026)

Does this generalize?

We ran an experiment:

- 100 websites $\times$ 6 frontier AI models
- Track which npm packages each model recommends
- Measure downloads (usage) vs stars (human attention)

The pattern holds

When AI recommends a package...	
Downloads	**+1.7 million/week**
Stars	**−10/week**

Usage **up**, engagement **down**

Two channels

Productivity
AI lowers cost of building OSS

Demand diversion
Users don't engage, maintainers lose **visibility**

How OSS maintainers earn returns

- Documentation visits $\rightarrow$ consulting leads
- Bug reports $\rightarrow$ reputation $\rightarrow$ job offers
- Stars/downloads $\rightarrow$ sponsorships

All require direct engagement

A model of the OSS ecosystem

- Developers create packages, decide whether to share
- Users choose packages, choose how to use them
- Vibe coding: higher productivity, lower engagement

$$\pi = \bar{\pi}(1 - v)$$

Revenue falls with vibe coding share v

Which channel wins?

Demand diversion is about 6x as big as productivity gains

Long-run equilibrium

- Entry falls $\rightarrow$ fewer new packages
- Variety shrinks $\rightarrow$ less choice
- Remaining packages may concentrate around superstars

Welfare can fall despite better AI

The magnification trap

The same feedback loop that grew OSS...

more entry $\rightarrow$ better ecosystem $\rightarrow$ lower costs $\rightarrow$ more entry

...now works in reverse

less entry $\rightarrow$ worse ecosystem $\rightarrow$ higher costs $\rightarrow$ less entry

What would save OSS?

84%

of revenue must come from visibility independent sources

A Spotify model for OSS

- AI platforms already track which packages they use
- Revenue sharing based on attributable usage
- Infrastructure for redistribution exists

Collapse or concentration?

Speculative—not in model, no data yet

Think **Linux distributions**: many $\rightarrow$ few (Ubuntu, Debian), but specialized distros persist for specific tasks

What we call "OSS" may be pushed down the abstraction ladder—feels like **operating system**, not tool

But users will still share high-level solutions... maybe in English

“Prompt Requests” not “Pull Requests”

“Pull requests are dead, long live prompt requests.”

Peter Steinberger (Pragmatic Engineer, 2026)

The collaboration layer may shift—from code to intent

Takeaway

Vibe coding is a **fundamental shift** in how software is produced and consumed.

The productivity gains are real. So is the threat to OSS.

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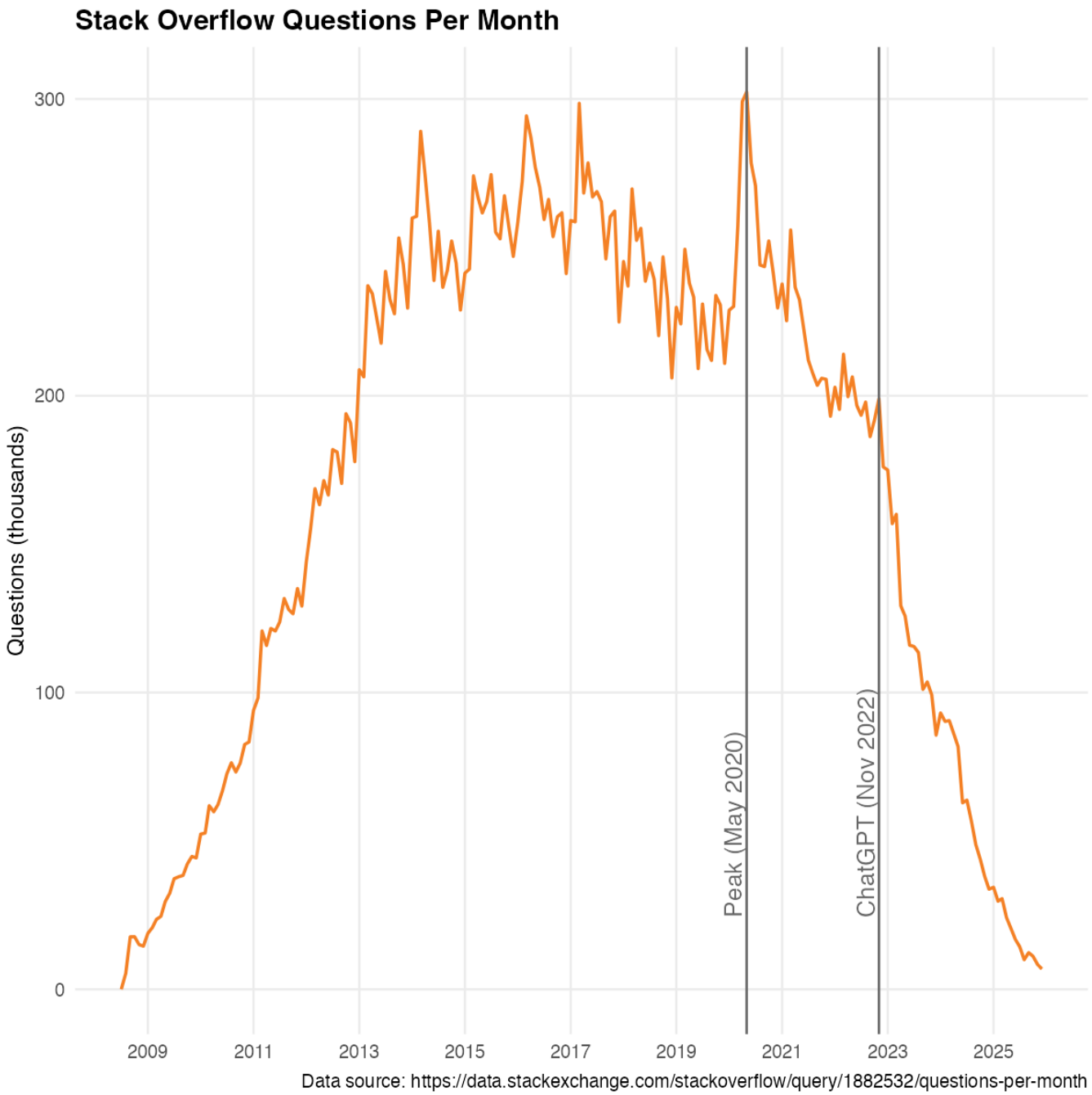
Appendix

Stack Overflow is dying